

# Setting up how a league works

Season calendars, competition structures, running a season stage by stage, and allocating grounds. A complete walkthrough for the union office.

## HOW A FIXTURE COMES TO EXIST



### Who this is for

Platform operators setting a client up, and union administrators running the season. No technical knowledge assumed.

2026 / 27 Season  
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PART ONE

# How a season is put together

Before any clicking, four ideas and the two ways in. They take five minutes and they make the rest of this guide obvious rather than fiddly.

## One league, one format, one setup

In the old model a league was just a name, and it ran one flat round robin. That works for EMCU Division 2. It does not work for KZNCU Premier Men, which plays a T20 Pink Ball tournament in seeded groups and a 50 Over Red Ball league split into a Top Six and a Bottom Six.

On the platform those are **two leagues**, "Premier Men T20" and "Premier Men 50 Over", the way the union's own catalogue already lists them. The same twelve clubs can be in both, grouped completely differently. Two formats always means two leagues.

Each league has one **setup**: the **structure** it plays through and the **season calendar** it plays on. The operator makes it. The structure also carries the match format, as its number of overs.

## A structure is a pipeline of stages

A stage is one phase of play. Premier Men 50 Over has two: a double round robin, then a final round after the mid-season swap. Each stage answers three questions, and only three.

| THE QUESTION    | WHAT YOU CHOOSE                                                                                                         |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Who plays?      | Every registered side · seeded into groups · chosen by the admin                                                        |
| Who plays whom? | Round robin (1, 2 or 3 legs) · knockout (seeded, cross-group or within-group) · single match · fixtures entered by hand |
| When?           | Which block of the calendar it plays in, and at what cadence                                                            |

A stage is not a block. A **block** is a stretch of dates on the season calendar, such as Block 1, 13 Sep to 13 Dec 2026. A **stage** is a phase of play. Each stage plays in one block, and the platform always says which: "Round-robin stage · plays in Block 1". Two stages can share a block, one after the other, or sit in different blocks either side of the break.

#### WHY SO FEW OPTIONS

The list is deliberately short and closed. Every one of the thirteen documented KZNCU and EMCU structures is expressible with these pieces, and a shorter list is a list you can hold in your head. If something genuinely doesn't fit, that is a conversation with the platform team, not a setting.

### One group becomes one series

When a stage generates, each of its groups becomes a **series** — the same thing the platform has always had. So approving, releasing, the player broadcast and the travel-cost figures all work exactly as they do today. Nothing new to learn there.

A Top Six therefore produces one series and a Bottom Six another. In the club portal those appear under a single season heading, so a club sees one season rather than two loose lists.

### Standings are typed by a human, on purpose

The platform does not record results. There is no ladder. That means a stage which depends on finishing order — the mid-season swap, the top four qualifying for semi-finals — cannot work itself out.

Rather than pretend, such a stage stops and asks. It quotes the rule back to you in the operator's own words, proposes the best grouping it honestly can, and waits. What you chose, what was proposed, and whether you accepted it are all recorded against your name.

#### THE ONE THING TO TAKE FROM PART ONE

The operator builds the *shape* once. The administrator runs the *season* through it every year, filling in the things only a human knows. Those are two different jobs, done by two different people, at two different times.

### Who does what

There is one way to set a league up and one way to start its season. The operator does the first, the administrator the second.

## WHO

## WHAT THEY DO

### The operator

**Set up a season** · **Set up**

The wizard, *Set up the season calendar & leagues*, has three steps: **season dates** (the calendar), **league structures** (a template or an existing structure per league), then **review & create**, which saves it all at once. For one league at a time, **Set up** on its row in the League catalogue does the same job. Parts Two, Four and Five cover what these screens ask.

### The administrator

**Start a season**

Picks a league the operator has set up, gives the season a label and starts it. Then works each stage: confirm entrants, generate, approve, release (Part Six).

#### OPERATORS SET UP, ADMINISTRATORS RUN

An administrator cannot create or change a league's setup, or edit a structure. A league the operator hasn't set up is listed in **Start a season** under *Not set up yet — ask your operator*. That is one message to the operator, instead of a season quietly started on the wrong dates.

The parts that follow are worth reading in full. They're what the wizard's steps are built from, and they're where the operator goes afterwards to edit a structure stage by stage, extend a calendar mid-season, or change one league's setup.

## Season calendars

Start here. The wizard's first step, *Season dates*, embeds this same form. Structures reference calendars, and leagues reference both, so the calendar has to exist before anything can point at it.

A season is not one continuous window. The KZNCU season is two **blocks** with a mid-season break between them: roughly 13 September to 13 December, then nothing until the third week of January, then through to the end of March.

Getting this right is what stops a ten-round league quietly scheduling its last three rounds into the Christmas holidays.

### Building one

**1** Open the operator console and find `Season calendars`

It sits on the client's settings page, above Venues and the structure library.

**2** Give it a label you'll recognise next year

`2026/27` is enough. This is what administrators see when they start a season, so it should read the way the union talks about the season.

**3** Add a block for each continuous stretch of play

Name it the way the union names it — `Block 1`, `First half`, whatever people actually say. Then set the first and last date on which a match could be played.

Dates are `YYYY-MM-DD`. A block that ends before it starts is refused, as is 31 February.

**4** Add the breaks

A break is a stretch inside the season when nobody plays. Fixture generation steps *over* a break rather than dropping the rounds that would have fallen in it, so a ten-round league still gets ten rounds, just later.

**5** Add excluded dates

Single days that are out: public holidays, exam weekends, the union's own AGM. Same behaviour as a break, just for one day.

**BEFORE YOU SAVE**

A calendar that a league's setup, a series or a running season uses cannot be deleted. The platform will refuse and tell you what is using it. That is deliberate: deleting it would strand a season nobody could regenerate.

**CHANGING DATES AFTER A SEASON HAS STARTED**

Edit the calendar and save. A season that has not generated fixtures yet picks up the new dates straight away, with nothing to delete or restart; its stage cards say *Dates follow the season calendar until you generate*. Once a season has generated fixtures its dates are frozen, and a calendar edit no longer moves them. To move a generated fixture, edit that fixture.

**What good looks like**

| FIELD    | KZNCU 2026/27                                |
|----------|----------------------------------------------|
| Label    | 2026/27                                      |
| Block 1  | 13 Sep 2026 → 13 Dec 2026                    |
| Block 2  | 18 Jan 2027 → 28 Mar 2027                    |
| Break    | Mid-season break · 14 Dec 2026 → 17 Jan 2027 |
| Excluded | 24 Sep 2026 (Heritage Day)                   |

## Venues

The master list of grounds fixtures can be played at. Second, because the allocator needs it and because you can seed most of it automatically.

### Seed it from the clubs you already have

Clubs have already told you their grounds during affiliation. The **Sync from club records** button reads every club's primary and secondary ground and creates a venue for each, with the club attached as a home side.

Two clubs naming the same ground get one venue with both attached. Ground-sharing is routine in club cricket and the allocator needs to know about it — it is exactly why "play at home" sometimes cannot be satisfied for both sides on the same Saturday.

### Then pin the coordinates by hand

#### THERE IS NO GEOCODER

The platform cannot look up a ground's position from its address. Somebody has to type the latitude and longitude. Secondary grounds have no coordinates at all in the club records, so they always start unpinned.

This matters more than it sounds. The allocator ranks grounds partly by travel, and a ground with no position would otherwise look like it is zero kilometres from everywhere and win every time.

So the Venues card shows a **coverage figure**: the share of grounds that have a position. Below 60%, the allocator switches distance ranking off entirely and falls back to home-ground preference alone. It tells you it has done this rather than quietly producing worse answers.

Getting a latitude and longitude is a thirty-second job: find the ground in Google Maps, right-click the middle of the square, and the first line of the menu is the pair of numbers. Durban grounds look like **-29.85** and **31.03** — southern latitudes are negative.

## The fields, and what each one changes

| FIELD                | WHAT IT DOES                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ground name          | What clubs and players see on the schedule. Required.                                                                                     |
| Suburb, Address      | Display only. Helpful on a printed fixture list.                                                                                          |
| Latitude / Longitude | Enables distance ranking. Optional, but see the coverage note above.                                                                      |
| Matches per day      | How many fixtures can be played here on one date. A two-pitch ground takes two. Default 1.                                                |
| Home clubs           | Which clubs call this home. Drives the "play at home" preference.                                                                         |
| Unavailable windows  | Maintenance, another sport's season, an exam period. Needs a reason — the reason is shown to the administrator when a fixture gets moved. |
| Unavailable weekdays | A ground that is never free on Sundays.                                                                                                   |

### REASONS ARE NOT PAPERWORK

When the allocator moves a fixture it quotes your reason back: "*Home ground outfield relaid — moved to the away side's ground.*" A club secretary can argue with that. They cannot argue with a fixture that simply appeared somewhere unexpected.

## Two settings with no card

**Venue aliases** tell the clash check that two spellings are one ground, so a fixture at either books the same field. **Travel cost** (rand per kilometre, cars per away trip) prices the travel estimates on the fixtures screens and the club portal. Neither has a card in the console: ask your platform operator to change them.

Match formats, match days and start times are no longer union-wide settings. The overs live on each structure (Part Four), and each stage picks its own days and times, starting from the platform's usual choices.

# Competition structures

The shape of a league's season, built once and reused. This is the heart of the feature and the part worth taking slowly. The wizard embeds it: its second step, *League structures*, picks a template or an existing structure per league, and **Adjust stages** opens this same stage editor inline. This part is what that step is choosing between.

## Start from a template, almost always

Six templates ship, and between them they cover all thirteen documented KZNCU and EMCU structures. A template is a **copy**, not a link. Once you pick one it is yours and fully editable, and changing it later never affects anything else.

| TEMPLATE                                   | USE IT FOR                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Flat round robin                           | Every EMCU division. One stage, everyone plays everyone.                                                                |
| Split league with mid-season swap          | KZNCU Premier Men 50 Over, Premier Women 30 Over.                                                                       |
| Seeded groups → cross-group semis → final  | Every T20 Pink Ball league.                                                                                             |
| Seeded groups → within-group semis → final | A league where each group produces its own finalist.                                                                    |
| Stream + knockout cup                      | Promotion Men: streams plus the Kingsmead Cup.                                                                          |
| One-off tournament                         | A cup or festival outside the league season. Pick the sides, get a seeded knockout spread across the dates you give it. |

When the calendar has two or more blocks, the wizard's second step asks which block each stage plays in (*Stage 2 plays in Block 2*), prefilled with the usual choice. Under each league it shows the **season narrative**: one plain sentence per stage, with its block and dates, so you can read what the season will do before anything is saved.

**Build from scratch** is there when nothing fits, and **Import JSON** is how you move a structure between clients or seed several at once without twenty rounds of clicking.

## Preview first, then Edit

Open a structure from the **Competition structures** card and it opens in **Preview**: the stages as plain sentences, the preview rail, and a picker to see the dates on any of the union's calendars. The line under the title says so: *You're previewing — nothing here changes anything.*

Press **Edit structure** to change it. The form opens with a strip that says what saving will change: every season using the structure, or just one of them (**Edit for**). **Discard changes**, or Esc, goes back to Preview without saving.

## Overs: the match format

A structure carries the match format as one number, **Overs**, next to its name in Edit mode. Leave it empty for 50. Every series the structure generates takes its overs from here and its name from the structure's name, so name structures the way clubs talk: **T20 seeded groups**, **50 Over split league**. A league that plays two formats is two leagues, each with its own structure.

### CHANGING OVERS DURING A SEASON

Saving a new name or overs makes a new version of the structure. A running season keeps the version it started with until the administrator opens **Review changes**, which shows a *Match format* line (*Was: ... · 50 overs, Now: ... · 30 overs*) and applies it. Fixtures already generated keep their old format until the administrator regenerates them; every stage with fixtures shows **Needs regenerating** until they do.

## Reading a stage

Collapsed, each stage is one plain sentence. That sentence is the point — you should be able to read a whole structure without expanding anything.

### STAGE 1 · ROUND-ROBIN STAGE

#### Double round

2 groups of 6 · plays every team twice, home and away · weekly · plays in Block 1



### STAGE 2 · ROUND-ROBIN STAGE

#### Final round

Chosen by the admin · plays every team once · weekly · plays in Block 2

## Three questions inside a stage

The stage editor asks the three questions from Part One, in order: **Who plays?**, **Who plays whom?** and **When?** Every choice that changes behaviour is an option card with a plain description, an example and a line on when to pick it. The *(i)* beside each one opens the longer explainer.

### Who plays? Where the entrants come from

| CHOICE                        | MEANING                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Every registered side         | Everyone entered in the league, in one group. This option cannot be split into groups.                             |
| Seeded into groups (snake)    | Dealt into groups by seed, back and forth: 1→A, 2→B, 3→B, 4→A. Seeds 1 and 2 always land in different groups.      |
| Seeded into groups (top-down) | Fills one group at a time in seed order, so the top half goes into group A. For tiers: a Top Six and a Bottom Six. |
| Chosen by the admin           | The admin types which sides play in each group when the stage opens. Used whenever the answer depends on results.  |

For every choice except the first you also set the group plan: **even groups** (say 4 groups, remainder lands in the earlier ones) or **exact sizes** ( 5, 5, 5, 4 — the only way to express the 19-team Promotion Men split).

### The rule, for stages chosen by the admin

When a stage depends on an earlier one, write the rule in plain English. This sentence is shown to the administrator when they confirm, and it is the whole instruction they get:

*Top Six 6th ↔ Bottom Six 1st, carrying the outgoing position's points*

Tick **points move with the position** if the swap carries points. The administrator then gets a box to enter them, and they are recorded as carried rather than calculated.

## Who plays whom? The format

| CHOICE                   | MEANING                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Single round robin       | Everyone in a group plays everyone once.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Double round robin       | Twice, home and away. The second leg mirrors the first.                                                                                                                                                          |
| Triple round robin       | Three times. Rare, but the model supports it.                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Knockout — seeded        | Standard bracket from the entrant order. Top two seeds can only meet in the final. A field that isn't 2, 4, 8 or 16 gets a preliminary round among the lowest seeds automatically.                               |
| Knockout — cross-group   | Each group winner plays another group's runner-up: A1 v B2 and B1 v A2. Needs the previous stage's finishing positions (see Part Six).                                                                           |
| Knockout — within-group  | Each group plays its own semi-final: A1 v A2 and B1 v B2, and the two winners meet in the final. Needs a power-of-two number of groups (2, 4 or 8), each sending the same power-of-two number of sides (2 or 4). |
| Single match             | One fixture. A final, a playoff.                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Fixtures entered by hand | The escape hatch. Generates no fixtures; the administrator adds them afterwards.                                                                                                                                 |

For a knockout fed by groups, the structure sets a default pairing. The administrator can choose the other one when confirming the qualifiers, for that season only.

## When? The block and the cadence

First, which block of the calendar the stage plays in. A stage that shares a block with an earlier one can be set to start after the previous stage finishes, on the same weekday. Then the cadence:

| CADENCE                 | MEANING                                                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weekly                  | One round each week, on the weekday the block starts.                     |
| Every N weeks           | You set the gap. Fortnightly for EMCU Division 3 Stream 2 and Division 4. |
| Set days only           | Only the weekdays you tick. Saturdays only, for EMCU Division 5.          |
| Spread across the block | Rounds spaced evenly from the block's first date to its last.             |

You can also add **time slots** (a T20 morning and afternoon), and an **activation date**: junior fixtures generated in September but not visible to clubs until the third week of January.

## Watch the preview rail

The panel beside the editor recalculates on every change, for a hypothetical number of teams you set. It shows the season narrative, fixture counts per group, rounds against cadence, the resulting date span, and whether it fits the block.

### THIS IS WHERE MISTAKES GET CAUGHT

*"11 rounds  $\times$  every 2 weeks = 22 weeks. Block 1 is 13 weeks — 9 weeks over."*

That is the EMCU Division 4 problem, found at design time in the operator console rather than in February with a club secretary on the phone. Shorten the cadence, split across blocks, or extend the block.

# Setting up a league

The step that puts a structure to work on a league's real clubs. Each league has one setup: a structure and a calendar. The wizard sets up several leagues at once; this part is for setting up, or changing, one league from the League catalogue.

- 1
- Open the **League catalogue** in the operator console

The **Setup** column shows each league's structure and calendar, or that it isn't set up yet.

- 2
- Press **Set up** on the league's row

It reads **Change setup** on a league that already has one.

- 3
- Pick the structure

A template (made fresh for this league) or one of the union's existing structures. Nothing is picked for you: the choice starts empty on purpose.

- 4
- Pick the calendar, and read the fit

The dialog checks every stage against the calendar's blocks and says whether each fits, and names any block no stage plays in. **Save** stays greyed out until both choices are made.

| LEAGUE              | STRUCTURE                                            | CALENDAR |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Premier Men 50 Over | Split league with mid-season swap · 50 overs         | 2026/27  |
| Premier Men T20     | Seeded groups → cross-group semis → final · 20 overs | 2026/27  |

Premier Men's two formats are two leagues, each set up on its own. There is no second setup on one league.

TWO CROSS-CHECKS HAPPEN ON SAVE

The structure and calendar must both still exist, and every stage's playing block must exist on the chosen calendar. A structure whose stages reference "Block 2" cannot be set up on a single-block calendar — you get told which stage and which calendar, on save, rather than months later at generation time.

### CHANGING A SETUP ONCE A SEASON IS RUNNING

A season that has generated fixtures keeps the calendar it generated with. A season with nothing generated yet follows its league's calendar, so pointing the league at a different calendar moves those dates too. The save tells you how many seasons will follow the new dates. At renewal time that is exactly what you want; mid-season, tell the administrator first.

## Next season: Run again

Each year the union needs new dates, not new leagues. Start the season wizard and enter the new calendar. Its second step lists every league already set up on another calendar under

**Run again**, such as *Premier Men 50 Over — Run again on 2027/28: Split league with mid-season swap*.

Tick the leagues that carry on ( **Select all** ticks every one). Each keeps its structure and moves to the new dates; nothing is re-created. Every row starts unticked, so a league you leave alone stays exactly where it was. A row is greyed out when its structure plays in a block the new calendar doesn't have. Fix the calendar, or set that league up by hand.

You can also add a league in step two and pick nothing for it. The review step then lists it as *added, but no structure picked — left unchanged*, and only the calendar is saved. That is how you create next year's calendar before deciding who plays on it.

### NO SETUP, NO SEASON

A league without a setup cannot start a season. In the administrator's **Start a season** it is listed under *Not set up yet — ask your operator*, and there is no way round that from the admin side.

## Running a season

The operator's work is done. This is the part the union office does every year.

### Start it

- 1 Admin console → Fixtures → Start a season**

Pick the league. The box under it says plainly which case you are in, and how many sides are registered for the league (with any not yet affiliated called out).
- 2 Only set-up leagues can start**

The list shows the leagues your operator has set up. The rest sit under *Not set up yet — ask your operator*. A league whose calendar has ended says so: ask the operator to renew the season dates.
- 3 Confirm the season label and start**

**Continue**, then confirm the season label. A summary shows the structure, its version and overs, the calendar, and how many groups each stage will make with the sides actually registered. A league runs one season per label: starting "2026/27" twice is refused.
- 4 Read "What happens next"**

The done screen shows a four-step strip: **Confirm entrants**, **Generate fixtures**, **Approve**, **Release**. That is the order you work each stage in, below.
- 5 The structure is frozen now, the calendar at first generate**

A copy of the structure is taken. If the operator edits it next week, your running season is untouched until you choose to adopt the new version with **Review changes**. The calendar keeps following the operator's changes until you first generate fixtures, then it is frozen too. Until then each stage card says *Dates follow the season calendar until you generate*, so a date fix from the operator never means deleting and restarting the season.

### Work the stages

Each stage is a card titled by its name and kind, such as *Double round · Round-robin stage*. Under the title:

- A **status timeline**: **Awaiting entrants** → **Ready** → **Generated** → **Released**. The current step carries a one-line hint of what to do. A stage is Released only when every one of its groups' series is out.

- **Plays in Block N** with its dates: the planned first and last round once the stage has groups, otherwise the block's own dates. For example, *Plays in Block 2 (After the break)* · 16 Jan 2027 → 27 Mar 2027.
- The stage's line from the **season narrative**, in plain English.
- **What the platform needs from you**: the seeding order, each group's finishing order, which sides play in each group, or nothing extra.

Two pills appear only when something needs attention:

| PILL               | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Doesn't fit        | The rounds need more time than the block allows. The reason is shown on the card.                                                                                                                                             |
| Needs regenerating | The entrants, the pairing or the schedule changed after generation, so the live fixtures no longer match. Also shown after <i>Review changes</i> applies a new name or overs: regenerating gives the fixtures the new format. |

### Confirming entrants

**Confirm entrants** opens a table of every registered side with a group dropdown against each. The rule is quoted at the top, and a suggestion is pre-filled — for a swap, the previous stage's groups with the two sides already exchanged.

**Use the suggestion** accepts it in one click. Or reassign by hand. **Not playing** is a legitimate answer for a side registered in the league but sitting this season out.

Live counts against the structure's expected sizes catch a miscount before it becomes a fixture list.

**Edit entrants** is on every stage, including one where every registered side plays. It is how you drop a side from a season. Sides whose club has not submitted its affiliation are listed greyed out, with a one-click **Include anyway**.

#### THE POSITION COLUMN

On a group stage that feeds a cross-group or within-group knockout, an extra **Position** column appears. Fill it in. The later bracket pairs sides by their finishing place in each group, so the order inside each group decides who plays whom.

Without it the draw falls back to a seeded bracket over the same teams and says so on the stage card. Right people, wrong pairings.

## Generating

**Generate 30 fixtures** (the button names the count) creates one series per group, named after the league and the stage. Generation runs on the server, through the same checks as any other fixture change, so a ground clash with another league is refused and listed rather than written. From there it is the ordinary path: check the fixtures, approve, release. Clubs and players see nothing until you release.

Each series shows the structure's name and its overs. Regenerating keeps whatever a series already shows, with one exception. When the operator changes the structure's name or overs, **Review changes** shows it as a *Match format* line (was and now). Once you apply it, each stage with fixtures reads **Needs regenerating**, and its next regenerate uses the new name and overs.

A stage whose fixtures are entered by hand shows **Create the series to enter fixtures** instead. It makes the empty series for you to fill.

### REGENERATING A RELEASED SCHEDULE

Regenerating is on the stage card, and only when the stage needs it. If any of the stage's series have already gone out, the console stops and asks first: *Regenerate a released schedule?* It names the series and says how many fixtures will replace them. **Replace the fixtures** cannot be undone. Allocated venues and hand-moved dates are lost, so to fix one fixture, edit that fixture instead.

## Stages wait for each other, and that is fine

A split league's first round generates and releases in September while the post-swap final round sits at **Awaiting entrants** until December. The season view shows both plainly, so nobody thinks half a season is missing.

### EVERY CONFIRMATION IS RECORDED

Who confirmed a stage's entrants, when, what was suggested, and whether they accepted it. Relegation and points carry ride on these decisions, so the trail is a governance record rather than a nicety. It cannot be edited or shortened afterwards.

## Series that are not part of a season

Some series on the Fixtures list carry a grey pill instead of a stage:

### PILL

### WHERE IT CAME FROM

|                           |                                                                          |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Imported schedule</b>  | Loaded in bulk from the union's own spreadsheet by the platform team.    |
| <b>Stand-alone series</b> | Made by hand before seasons existed, through the old create-series form. |

Both are ordinary series. You can add, edit and delete their fixtures, allocate grounds, approve, release and recall them as usual. What you cannot do is regenerate them: there is no stage to rebuild them from. To reshape an imported schedule, the platform team re-imports it.

## Allocating grounds

A separate pass, run after fixtures exist. It decides where each match is played.

### What it is trying to do

In order of priority, and the order is yours to change:

1. **Home preference.** Play at the home side's ground.
2. **Distance.** Prefer the ground with less combined travel.
3. **Availability.** Prefer a quieter ground, all else equal.

When the home ground will not work, it falls back in this order:

home ground → the club's secondary ground → the away side's ground → the nearest available neutral ground

### The ledger covers every league at once

#### THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT THING HERE

Allocation looks at **every series in the union**, not just the one you are allocating. Premier Men 50 Over and Premier Men T20 are two leagues competing for the same grounds on the same Saturday, and a side must not be scheduled twice in one day across the two.

### Reading the result

| STATUS      | MEANING                                                                  |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Home        | At the home side's ground, as intended.                                  |
| Alternative | Moved to the away side's ground. The reason says why.                    |
| Neutral     | Neither side's ground. The reason says why, with the travel figure.      |
| Unresolved  | It could not place this fixture and is telling you rather than guessing. |

Every fixture carries a reason. That is the deliberate trade: a cleverer algorithm could squeeze out a few more kilometres, but it could not explain itself to a club secretary on the phone.

## Hand-picked grounds are kept

Set a ground by hand on a fixture and re-allocation will not move it. It claims its slot before everything else competes, so a manual decision is never quietly undone. A padlock on the row shows which fixtures are held.

## Two reports worth reading afterwards

**Home and away balance** per side — the crude alternation can leave a club with six home and four away. Worth a look before release.

**Travel per club** — minimising total kilometres can quietly dump the burden on one club. The per-club figure is the one that matters for fairness.

## Releasing, and holding grounds back

The **release bar** under a series' fixtures is the single place to approve, release, reveal and recall it. The page never offers the same action twice.

At release you can withhold venues, start times or both. Clubs then see *venue to be confirmed* or *time to be confirmed* until you reveal them from the same bar. A withheld fixture still books its real ground, so the clash check sees it and nobody else can take that ground on that day.

PART EIGHT

# Worked examples

Four real leagues, exactly as they are configured. Each is its own league with its own setup; Premier Men appears twice because its two formats are two leagues.

## EMCU Division 4 — the simplest thing that works

SINGLE STAGE

League season

Every registered side · plays every team once · every 2 weeks · plays in Block 1

One stage, template untouched. The only unusual thing is the fortnightly cadence — and it is the reason to watch the preview rail, because eleven rounds at that cadence needs 22 weeks and Block 1 is 13.

## KZNCU Premier Men 50 Over · Red Ball

STAGE 1

Double round

2 groups of 6, chosen by the admin · plays every team twice · weekly · plays in Block 1

↓ 6th of the Top Six swaps with 1st of the Bottom Six, carrying points

STAGE 2

Final round

2 groups of 6, chosen by the admin · plays every team once · weekly · plays in Block 2

Structure set to 50 overs. 30 fixtures per group in stage 1, ten per team — matching the union's own spreadsheet. The swap is the interesting part: it is a rule written in words, a suggestion the platform pre-fills, and a human decision recorded against a name.

## KZNCU Premier Men T20 • Pink Ball

### STAGE 1

#### Group stage

2 groups of 6, seeded into groups (snake) • plays every team once • weekly • plays in Block 1

↓ top two of each group qualify • set the **Position** column

### STAGE 2

#### Cross-group semi-finals and final

Chosen by the admin • knockout, cross-group • plays in Block 2

Structure set to 20 overs. Snake seeding puts the top two seeds in different groups. The semis pair A1 against B2 and B1 against A2, then the final references the two winners — so the bracket reads "Winner of Semi-final 1" until the results are known.

## KZNCU Promotion Men • Hollywoodbets Kingsmead Cup

### SINGLE STAGE

#### Kingsmead Cup

9 sides, chosen by the admin • knockout, seeded • weekly • plays in Block 2

The bottom ten minus the last-placed side leaves nine. Nine is not a power of two, so one preliminary match reduces it to eight, then quarter-finals, semi-finals and a final. The preliminary is derived automatically — you enter nine names and get the right bracket.

### ONE DELIBERATE DIVERGENCE

The union's spreadsheet pairs its semi-finals in a way that would let seeds 1 and 2 meet before the final. The platform uses the standard bracket instead, which keeps them apart. The set of quarter-finals is identical; only the semi-final pairing differs.

## PART NINE

# What the messages mean

Everything the console might tell you, and what to do about it.

| MESSAGE                                                                   | WHAT TO DO                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 11 rounds × every 2 weeks = 22 weeks. Block 1 is 13 weeks — 9 weeks over. | The stage does not fit its block. Shorten the cadence, move it to a longer block, split it across two, or extend the block on the calendar.                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Group B has no sides, so it generates no fixtures.                        | A group was left empty when entrants were confirmed. Reopen <a href="#">Edit entrants</a> and assign somebody, or reduce the group count on the structure.                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Group A has one side — it would play nobody.                              | Same fix. A group needs at least two.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Give every side in Group A a finishing position.                          | You are on a stage that feeds a cross-group or within-group draw, or on a seeded knockout, and a side has no position. Fill in the Position column for everyone in the group.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Group A has two sides in the same position.                               | Two sides share a finishing position. One of them has to move.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Paired as a seeded bracket, not cross-group.                              | The qualifying groups do not line up with this stage's entrants, or qualify unevenly. Confirm the group stage's finishing positions, then re-check this stage. The fixtures are correct in personnel, just not paired across groups.                                                                                                                      |
| Paired as a seeded bracket, not within-group.                             | Same cause, plus one more: within-group needs a power-of-two number of groups (2, 4, 8), each sending the same power-of-two number of sides. Three groups, or groups sending different numbers, cannot be drawn without a bye. Confirm the group stage's finishing positions, or pick cross-group pairing for this season when confirming the qualifiers. |
| 3 registered sides are in no group.                                       | Clubs joined the league after entrants were confirmed. The confirmation is deliberately frozen, so open <a href="#">Edit entrants</a> and add them.                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| 1 side in a group is no longer registered.                                | A club left the league. Remove it from the group, then regenerate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| The entrants changed after these fixtures were generated.                 | The live series still hold the old groups. Regenerate to bring them into line — and read the confirmation carefully if they are released.                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Only 40% of venues have a pinned location.                                | Travel distance was ignored for this allocation. Pin more grounds and re-allocate to get distance ranking back.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## MESSAGE

## WHAT TO DO

One of these sides already has a match that day.

The fixture is unresolved because a side is already committed, possibly in another league. Move the date, or accept it and place the fixture by hand.

Every available ground is already booked that day.

More fixtures than ground capacity. Add grounds, raise "matches per day" on a two-pitch ground, or spread the round.

This league has no season setup yet — ask your operator to set it up in the operator console.

Only the operator can set a league up: **Set up** on its row in the League catalogue, or the season wizard. Nothing to do on the admin side until then.

This league's setup points at a structure (or calendar) that no longer exists — ask your operator.

The structure or calendar was removed after the league was set up with it. The operator needs to change the league's setup.

This league's season dates have ended — ask your operator to renew them.

Last season's calendar is still the league's setup. The operator extends it, or changes the setup to a new calendar.

That season label is already running for this league — pick a different label or continue the existing season.

The league already has a season with that label. Open it from the Fixtures list, or give the new one a different label.

2 ungenerated season runs of "Premier Men 50 Over" will follow the new dates.

Operator only, after saving a league setup with a different calendar. Seasons with nothing generated yet move to the new dates; generated ones don't. Expected at renewal; mid-season, tell the administrator.

The structure's name or overs changed when you reviewed its changes — regenerating adopts them for these series.

You applied a new structure version with a different name or overs. Existing fixtures keep the old format until you press *Regenerate* on the stage. If the series are released, read the *Regenerate a released schedule?* prompt first.

This console is out of date — refresh it and try again.

The operator page was loaded before an update and tried to save something the platform no longer uses. Nothing was saved. Refresh and make the change again.

Some of this stage's fixtures are released; the console will ask before replacing them.

Another tab or person released a series after your page loaded. Refresh, press generate again, and read the *Regenerate a released schedule?* prompt before replacing anything.

# Reference

## Who can do what

| TASK                                   | OPERATOR             | ADMINISTRATOR   | CLUB REP |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------|-----------------|----------|
| Season calendars                       | Create and edit      | Read            | —        |
| Competition structures                 | Create and edit      | Read            | —        |
| Set up a league (structure + calendar) | Yes                  | —               | —        |
| Venues                                 | —                    | Create and edit | Read     |
| Venue aliases, travel cost             | On request (no card) | —               | —        |
| Start and run a season                 | —                    | Yes             | —        |
| Confirm entrants                       | —                    | Yes             | —        |
| Generate, approve, release             | —                    | Yes             | —        |
| Allocate grounds                       | —                    | Yes             | —        |

### WHY VENUES ARE THE ADMINISTRATOR'S, NOT THE OPERATOR'S

A ground going out for maintenance is a week-to-week fact the union office learns first. Routing it through the platform operator would make the schedule permanently stale.

## Glossary

### Block

A stretch of dates on the season calendar during which matches can be played, such as Block 1, 13 Sep to 13 Dec 2026. A calendar usually has two, separated by a break. A block is dates, never a phase of play.

### Cadence

How often rounds are played: weekly, every N weeks, on set weekdays, or spread evenly across the block.

### Cross-group

A knockout that pairs one group's winner against another group's runner-up, so group rivals cannot meet again immediately.

### Edit / Preview

The two modes of the structure editor. A structure opens in Preview, where nothing can change; *Edit structure* switches to the form, and Esc or *Discard changes* goes back.

### **Group**

A set of teams within a stage that play each other. A Top Six is a group. Each group becomes one series. The platform says "group" everywhere; older union documents may say "pool".

### **League**

One entry in the union's catalogue, such as "Premier Men 50 Over". Clubs register for it. It has at most one setup. Two formats for the same clubs are two leagues.

### **Overs**

The match format, set on the structure. Empty means 50. Every series the structure generates takes its overs from here.

### **Preliminary round**

An extra opening round that trims a knockout field to a power of two. Nine entrants need one; eight need none.

### **Run again**

The season wizard's way to renew a league for next year: it moves the league's setup to the new calendar and keeps its structure. Nothing is re-created.

### **Season**

One league being played out this year (a season run). Holds which teams are in which group at each stage. Freezes the structure it started with, and freezes the calendar when it first generates fixtures; until then it follows the league's calendar. Started from *Start a season*.

### **Series**

The existing unit of fixtures. One stage-group becomes one series, so everything downstream is unchanged. A new series is labelled with the structure's name and overs.

### **Setup**

What a league plays through: one structure and one season calendar. Made and changed only by the operator, with *Set up* on the league's row or in the season wizard.

### **Snake seeding**

Splitting seeds 1,2,3,4 into two groups as A,B,B,A rather than A,A,B,B — it keeps the top seeds apart.

### **Stage**

One phase of play in a structure. A split league has two: the double round and the final round. A stage is titled by its kind (Round-robin stage, Knockout stage, Final, Hand-entered stage) and plays in one block.

### **Structure**

The reusable shape of a league's season: its stages, in order, and its overs. Built once by the operator, usually from a template, and used season after season.

### **Unresolved**

A fixture the allocator could not place, shown with the reason. Deliberately visible rather than placed somewhere wrong.

### **Within-group**

A knockout where each group plays its own semi-final (A1 v A2, B1 v B2) and the group winners meet in the final. Needs a power-of-two number of groups, each sending the same power-of-two number of sides.

## **Two things this does not do yet**

**Results and standings.** The platform does not record scores, so no stage can work out its own qualifiers. Every standings-dependent decision is typed by a human and recorded. If results capture is ever added, the rules already written into your structures become automatic without you re-entering anything.

**Scoring-platform sync.** Not built. It needs the scoring platform named, its API documented, and a decision on how team identities map between the two systems.

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Smart Club Platform · Setting up how a league works · Version 2.2 · September 2026

Technical detail: [docs/architecture/0008-configurable-league-structures.md](#) , [docs/architecture/0014-seasons-one-vocabulary-one-path-one-engine.md](#)

Deploying this feature: [docs/runbooks/configurable-league-structures.md](#)